

VALUING YOUR TIME

How to estimate, track and monetize the investment in this project — handbook companion chapter · itc-hybrid-prj · v1.0

A project with a price tag gets treated differently than a hobby — even by its own owner. This chapter turns the hours you invest into numbers: what they cost, what they buy, and how to track them without turning learning into labor. In doing so, you take on the last role on the org chart you had not yet played: the sponsor, who owns the budget and the business case.

Your time is not free just because nobody invoices it. Economists call this opportunity cost: every evening spent here is an evening not spent on something else. Pricing it honestly is what makes the project's business case real.

1. Give Your Hour a Price

There are three defensible ways to set your hourly rate, and each tells a different story:

Method	How to calculate	The story it tells
Current-salary rate	Gross monthly salary ÷ ~160 working hours. Ballpark for a Stockholm L1–L3 role: 200–250 SEK/hour.	“What my time costs today.” Use this one for tracking — it is honest.
Target-salary rate	Same math on the infrastructure-engineer salary you are aiming for. Likely 300–350+ SEK/hour.	“What my time is becoming worth.”
Market consultant rate	What a company would pay an external specialist for this work: easily 800–1,200 SEK/hour.	The replacement value of what you are building. Keep it for motivation: one evening here produces work worth several thousand kronor.

Recommendation: track with the **current-salary rate** and set it as a parameter in the project charter — it defines the project's personnel budget. Insert your real salary figures; the ballparks above are only placeholders.

2. Estimate the Total, Then Track the Actual

Apply the standard estimation logic to yourself. A sustainable pace alongside work and life is roughly 6–10 hours per week. A defensible early ballpark for the full build, at learning speed, is 250–400 hours of effort — and remember, ±50% is a respectable margin at this stage (the cone of uncertainty applies to you too).

Parameter	Example value	Notes
Weekly pace	6–10 hours	Sustainable beats heroic. Pacing is part of the methodology.
Total effort estimate	250–400 hours	Sharpens after Phase 0, exactly like a real project at its gates.
Hourly rate (example)	225 SEK	Your charter parameter — replace with your real number.

Parameter	Example value	Notes
Personnel budget	≈55,000–90,000 SEK	Hours × rate. A five-figure investment — which is why it gets a charter, a plan and phase gates.
Calendar duration	≈8–14 months	Effort ÷ weekly pace. Dependencies and life add stretch — that is normal.

The tracking method (ten seconds per task)

Tracking must be nearly effortless or it will not happen. Two small fields on every Kanban card:

Field	When you fill it	Example
Est:	When the card enters Ready — your honest guess in hours.	Est: 3h
Act:	When the card moves to Done — what it really took.	Act: 5h

Once a month, sum the actuals and write one line in the changelog or learning log: “Month 2: 31 hours invested, ≈7,000 SEK. Phase 0 complete.” That single line is a burn report — the same thing a PM shows a steering committee.

The hidden second prize

Estimate versus actual, card after card, calibrates your estimating instinct — a genuinely rare skill. Within a couple of months you will have personal data (“I estimate documentation tasks well; I underestimate network tasks by half”) and the evidence to prove it in an interview.

3. The Return: Why This Math Is Worth Doing

Tracking the input is bookkeeping; the real number is the return. Yours is unusually concrete, because the project has a stated business goal: transitioning from support to infrastructure roles.

Line	Example figure	Basis
One-time investment	≈55,000–90,000 SEK	Your evenings, priced at the current-salary rate.
Salary uplift (support → infra)	7,000–10,000 SEK / month	Plausible step in Sweden — verify against real job ads and pencil in your own figures.
Annual return	84,000–120,000 SEK / year, recurring	Uplift × 12. Repeats every year after.
Payback period	Under one year in the new role	Investment ÷ annual return.

Very few investments available to a private person have this profile. And there is a second-order return that is harder to price but real: every future salary negotiation starts from the higher baseline, compounding for the rest of a career.

The defense against discouragement

These numbers have a gentler purpose too. Somewhere around Phase 2, when PKI is being stubborn at 22:30 on a Tuesday, “why am I doing this” will visit. On that evening the answer is sitting in the changelog, in kronor: this is a project with a positive business case, approved by the sponsor — who is you — and currently on budget.

4. One Caution, From the Mentor

Track the hours, but never let the meter turn learning into labor. If a week produces zero hours because life happened, the project is not “over budget” — the pacing principle outranks the spreadsheet. The numbers serve the story; never the reverse.

Where these numbers live

The hourly rate and total-effort estimate are charter-level parameters — they go into docs/governance/project-charter.md (Phase 0, Task 1). The Est/Act fields go on every Kanban card. The monthly burn line goes in the changelog. Nothing new to maintain — the system you already have carries all of it.